Saddleworld
A WORLD OF DIFFERENCE

2013 Australian Dressage Championships



EVENT REPORT

Report to Sponsors



Photo: Franz Venhaus 2013

Overview

The 2013 Championships featured an extended programme covering four and half days of competition. We are pleased to report that the terrible bush fires that raged around the Sydney area in the lead up and during the event did not hinder the running of the event. The championships went ahead as planned and the only change made was to move the Para-Equestrian competitions on Wednesday indoors. The forecast on that day was for extremely hot and windy conditions and the indoor provided a safer environment for the athletes and more pleasant conditions for the judges and volunteers.

The Technical Delegate (Kim Thomas WA) was impressed with the organization and planning of the event and its execution. President of the Ground Jury Col. Axel Steiner (USA) and other visiting judges were impressed with the standard of competition and the professional conduct of the event.

The support and co-operation of the SIEC venue management and staff was again first class. The venue was well prepared, looked great and the arenas rode well. There were no real issues with the surfaces and the competitors were appreciative of the attention given to the arenas so that they had every opportunity to perform at their best.

Spectator numbers overall were down 5.7% on 2012. The fall out in numbers this year was mainly on Friday. On Saturday we had the same number of paying spectators as the previous year.

On-line ticket sales for Saturday were tracking above last year and we had hoped for a similar trend to continue on the day with gate sales. The fires around Sydney and NSW in the lead up and during the event did impact on visitors with many reluctant to leave their homes and animals in such unpredictable weather conditions.

We do not know whether the live streaming broadcasts of feature events (see below) also reduced attendance at the event.

Combined with this, Equitana in Sydney two weeks after the Championships did take away spectators, especially interstate and NSW country visitors. We are pleased to say that many sponsors and exhibitors reported they made budget and that their attendance was worthwhile.

The budget for the event is around $280,000. Any profit received from this event goes into general revenue for Dressage NSW and is used to develop the sport or a portion is put back into the event.

We are still finalising the accounts and it is the outcome will be tight. We are hopeful that we may just manage to cover our costs.



The Champions

Birds Equisport Novice Championships

Champion: Rodney Martin (NSW) - SS Dante

Reserve Champ: Kate Taylor-Wheat (NSW) – Flowervale Florenz

Wagners Elementary Championships

Champion: Rodney Martin (NSW) - SS Dante

Reserve: Emma Flavelle (QLD) – Cabaret C

CSG Medium Championships

Champion: Daniella Dierks (NSW) – World Royal

Reserve: Melissa Van den Berge (QLD) - Doornkaat

IRT Advanced Championships

Champion: Daniella Dierks (NSW) – World Royal

Reserve: Nicole Tough (QLD) – Furst Tyme

Needs for Steeds Prix St Georges Championships

Champion: Janina Kletke (NSW) – Bluefields Floreno

Reserve: Tor Van den Berge (QLD) – Lauries AS

Mulawa Performance Intermediate I Championships

Champion: Tor Van den Berge (QLD) – Lauries AS

Reserve: Robbie Soster (NSW) - Robali Razzamattaz

Equestrian NSW Intermediate II Championships

Champion: Alexis Hellyer (NSW) – Waca W

Reserve: Victoria Welch (QLD) - Bretanus

Australian Sports Commission Grand Prix CDI-W

Maree Tomkinson (VIC) - Diamantina IV

Pessoa Dressage Grand Prix Freestyle CDI-W

Sheridyn Ashwood (QLD) – Prestige VDL

Winner of the Pryde's EasiFeeds CDI-Y

Victoria Stuckey (VIC) – Mayfield Miracle

National Championship Special Awards

EA Grand Prix Champion

Sheridyn Ashwood (QLD) – Prestige VDL

Prix St Georges Challenge Winner

Janina Kletke (NSW) – Bluefields Floreno

Rod Barker Memorial Trophy winner

Rodney Martin (NSW) - SS Dante

Dietmar Spect Trophy

Daniella Dierks (NSW) – World Royal

Crown Law Trophy (and winner of the Pessoa Dressage Grand Prix Special)

Sheridyn Ashwood (QLD) – Prestige VDL





Para Equestrian Champions

Grade 1A: Morgan Webb-Liddle (VIC) – Don Armani

Grade 1B: Joann Formosa (VIC) – Worldwide PB

Grade II: Anne Skinner (VIC) – Aubaine Cossack

Grade III: Chelsea Higgins (QLD) – Comedia

Grade IV: Hannah Dodd (NSW) – Grand Sam

National Competition winners:

Agnes Banks Equine Clinic Grand Prix

Jayden Brown (QLD) - Furst Frederich

Trailrace 4 yr old young horse

Janina Kletke - Bluefields Berlin

Top Horse 5 yr old young horse

Tor van den Berge (QLD) - Remi Frangellica

The Riders Shoppe 6 yr old young horse

Rodney Martin (NSW) - SS Dante

Competition

The National Titles always attract Australia's best talent and this year was no exception. Around 275 horses and over 180 Australian riders entered making this the highest number of horses ever with competitors from all states accept Tasmania taking part. Not all horses entered get a start due to the maximum number of competitors allowed (max 35) at each level. The standard of competition was high and some promising new combinations provided pretty stiff competition across all levels.

In general terms NSW riders took out most of the Championships titles and in contrast to last year the majority were female riders.

Accreditation: 460 wrist bands were issued to competitors, grooms and owners. The wristbands allow the wearer to free admission to the venue at all times.

The inclusion of Para-Equestrian was a positive experience and is likely to continue in the future.

The Grand Prix CDI-W provided an opportunity for Australia-based riders and two New Zealand combinations to qualify for the Pacific League Final held at the end of December in Melbourne.

For the first time we offered on-line entries for the event on Nominate. It took some time to set up due to the qualification requirements. Around 65% of horses were entered via Nominate and 35% sent in manual entries. Lessons learnt this year will assist with future events and by working with Nominate we hope to be able to iron out a few issues.

All competitors received a welcome show bag, a complimentary programme booklet, a souvenir stable plaque, a Saddleworld water bottle and other goodies and handouts provided by our sponsors.

Judges

Three FEI-accredited foreign judges officiated this year including one FEI 5* (Olympic-level) Judge:

Col. Axel Steiner (USA - 5*), Mrs. Lorraine MacDonald (Canada - 4*), Mrs. Tiina Karkkolainen (Finland – 3*). The foreign judges were joined by Australian colleagues Susan Hoevenaars (5*), Virginia Creed (4*), Ricky MacMillan (*4), Maria Schwennesen (4*), Gisela Nillson-Harding (3*), Jane Ventura (3*), along with 18 National-level Judges from NSW, Queensland, South Australia, Tasmania and Victoria.

Five Dock Jeep provided vehicles for our Judges to judge from. Gifts for officials were provided by from Coty Australia and Hamag.

Volunteers

Around 80 volunteers (plus the organising committee and officials, who are also volunteers) were in attendance each day. Many are regulars who look forward to these events each year.





Volunteers from near and far assisted at the event with some travelling from interstate to gain experience. The event volunteers do a variety of jobs such as writing for judges, collecting test papers, scoring, hospitality, office duties, arena maintenance, stewarding, marshalling, stabling and camping related jobs.

Volunteers were offered "Gift Vouchers" that they can redeem at petrol stations, supermarkets or other retail outlets. All volunteers in the public eye (runners, gate keepers, stewards etc) were given a Saddleworld Polo Shirt to wear while on duty. They also received a gift voucher from Hamag as were eligible for daily prizes. Volunteers went in to an overall draw to win Two tickets to Equitana on Saturday.



Meals and refreshments were provided.

Spectators

As noted earlier gate takings overall were below last year.

Ticket prices have remained similar for the last five years. We were conscious of the low attendance rate in 2012 and admission fees were reviewed and altered slightly this year. We reverted to not charging a fee on Thursday and the lifted the age for "Child" ticket prices from 12 years to 16 years and under on Saturday. Ticket prices at the gate:

Adults: Thursday: free; Friday: $15; Saturday $25; Sunday: $10.

Children 16 years and under: Free entry Thu. Fri and Sun. $15 on Saturday.

The option of booking a reserved seat (patrons can choose their seat) online for Saturday was available via the web site for $30. We used a different system this year where people printed their own tickets from home. This allowed us to continue selling allocated seats right up to the day before. Our on line ticket sales for Saturday were tracking around 20% above the previous year and we were hopeful that the trend would continue at the gate on the day.

The number of people on the grounds each day:

- Thursday: 400;
- Friday: 600;
- Saturday: 1030;
- Sunday: 500.
- Total: 2630*

Ticket sales overall were similar to last year with Friday being lower than in 2012. The fires would have contributed to this result.

The number of people on the ground was higher due to more horses and riders taking part.

* These figures are taken from general gate sales, pre-purchased tickets (day passes and VIP tickets), volunteers, officials, guests, sponsors, riders, grooms, owners and exhibitors. Excludes ticket sales to the Saturday evening dinner.







Hospitality

We changed the format for the Saturday evening dinner to a buffet and dropped the price to $120 pp (a reduction of $30). Despite this the number of tickets sold was disappointing. The layout was altered and the number of tables reduced and spread out. Sponsors whose sponsor package did not include the dinner were offered a discount for tickets for the dinner – a popular move. Two tables were set aside for our Judges in the Marquee on Saturday night and the judges were "over the moon" to be included.



Media & Promotion

The accreditation for press and photographers included access to the fully catered VIP Hospitality area (except for the Saturday night dinner). In the press room, journalists also had free access to Broadband Internet connection, results and tea/coffee facilities. Photographers and press were able to reserve seats in the public seating area on Saturday evening.

Media Exposure

We had coverage in some regional papers and, of course, all the equestrian publications ran stories. Despite our efforts, getting mainstream publicity for dressage (and any other equestrian discipline is not easy). Stories, pictures and results were sent out daily during the event to various media and web sites and our own web site, www.dressagensw.com.au

Dressage NSW website attracted **606,123** page views over the 3 months August, September and October.

Advertising

August
The Horse Magazine
Horse Deals
September
The Horse Magazine
Horse Deals
October
Equestrian Life
Hills & Hawkesbury Equestrian News
Hunter 2 Hawkesbury Equestrian News

Other adverts for the event appeared in various publications such as Public Arena, Dressage with the Stars programme booklet, Equestrian NSW Yearbook, Centreline.

5000 Promotional postcards were printed and distributed as well as colour A3 and A4 posters.

Video/live streaming

A promotional video was produced and featured on various websites and on YouTube

Equestrian Life

Equestrian Life live streamed the feature events on Friday, Saturday and Sunday.

A wrap up video of the event was produced

A large number of Freestyle and other tests were loaded and available for download from the Equestrian Live Video gallery.

A general interest article was circulated each week in the six weeks leading up to the event. The articles featured stories on riders from various locations including: Lisa Martin (Upper Hunter NSW), Kate Taylor-Wheat (Glenorie NSW), Brett Parbery (Southern Highlands NSW), Fern Wright (VIC).

Video You Tube coverage

The top three tests from the Intermediate and Grand Prix Freestyle tests were filmed and posted on You Tube for viewing. Over ***6900*** view of these videos including the promotitional video

In addition, Equestrian Life also posted Videos of many of the tests and a wrap up video of the event. Download numbers counted were in excess 5000.

Editorial magazine/press exposure

- The Horse Magazine
- Centreline
- Public Arena
- Fairfax Community papers (The Hills area)
- Local Fairfield-Blacktown press were to feature a story on local volunteers (no riders in the area)
- Hills Shire Times
- Southern Highlands
- Eventful Life
- Other regional papers carried stories on local riders but difficult to obtain copies.

During the event a report went out daily covering the competition highlights.

Website exposure

- Equestrian Australia and EA Branch websites
- Dressage NSW
- Equestrian Life
- Horsedeals
- Cyberhorse
- Tophorse
- Horsezone
- Eurodressage
- Local Horse Magazine
- An Eventful Life
- Dressage Direct (featured results)
- Dressage News (USA)

Some of the above featured links to the stories and news items on Social media as well.

606,123 page views were recorded on the Dressage NSW website for the three months, August, September, october.

Post event coverage of the event featured in the following publications:

- The Horse Magazine
- Equestrian Live
- Hawkesbury Hills Equestrian News
- Centreline
- Other publications are likely to have carried stories.

Equestrian Life Live streamed most of the feature competitions as well as producing video interviews and other behind the scenes videos.

Other exposure for sponsors

Naming Sponsor Saddleworld logo or name featured on all promotional items as well as on competition schedules, time draws, results, trophies, ribbons, competitor listings and rider information packs and other forms of communication

Principal partners, Australian Sports Commission, Equestrian Australia, Equestrian NSW and their logos were featured on most promotional material.

The Saddleworld logo or name featured on the DNSW and ENSW home page in a feature box linking to the event information section of the web. For a period Equestrian Australia featured the same image on the EA home page under the Events rotating feature box.

Saddleworld, principal partners along with major event sponsors logos featured on the web site with a link to the sponsor web site.

All sponsor logos featured on advertising, flyers and brochures where possible.

Sponsor names featured on rosettes/sashes/ trophies for sponsored competition

Sponsor logos featured on A frames and other signs located at the venue.

Event programme booklet

A 74 page (A4) programme booklet was printed. Complimentary copies were given to all competitors, owners, VIPs and officials. 800 copies were produced. Sponsor and other adverts appeared in the publication.

Public Address

Gary Wilkinson assisted with the production of the CD featuring sponsor PA announcements. The CD was played throughout the event.



Our Sponsors and Supporters

Major Sponsor

- Saddleworld

Principal Partners

- Equestrian Australia
- Equestrian NSW
- The Australian Sports Commission

Sponsors

- Agnes Banks Equine Clinic
- Birds Equisport
- CSG
- Gow–Gates
- International Racehorse Transport
- Mulawa Performance
- Needs for Steeds
- Pryde's EasiFeed
- The Riders Shoppe
- Trailrace
- Top Horse
- Wagners Saddlery

Official Suppliers & Supporters

- Equilibrium
- Five Dock Jeep
- Hamag
- Mandavilla Catering Services
- Coty Australia
- CSG Print Services
- Sydney Dressage Inc
- Sydney International Equestrian Centre
- Wild Oats
- The Branches of Equestrian Australia

Media Partner

Equestrian Life

Promotional Support

Australian Horse Deals, The Horse Magazine, Top Horse

Programme booklet advertisers

- Aitkins Saddlery
- Auction of the Stars,
- Brighton Saddlery
- Capricorn
- Country Park Herbs,
- Equissage,
- Equilibrium,
- International Horse Breeders,
- Kelvin Grove Equestrian,
- The Dancing Horse
- Saddle Up

Contra arrangements are in place to cross promote events with advertisements featured for up coming major dressage events.

Exhibitors

- Aitkins Saddlery
- AKA Quality
- Anky Australia
- Birds Equisports
- Boeckmann Australia
- Brighton Saddlery
- CF Equestrian Style
- Dubarry
- ecofibre Industries
- Edinburgh Horse Rugs
- Equissage Therapy
- Equissentials
- Horse & Hound Specialist
- Horse & Pet Direct
- Horseland
- Horsewerks
- Horsequest
- Kalarose Equestrian Wear
- Kelato Animal Health
- Kelvin Grove Equestrian
- Main Event Photography
- Mous Boots
- My Riding Boots
- Pryde's Easifeed
- Redgum Saddlery
- Saddle-Up Saddleworld
- Saddleworld
- The Horse Rider Physio
- The Riders Shoppe
- The Tack Shed
- Trailrace
- Wagners Saddlery



Trade Show

Numbers were slightly higher than the previous year, which was a good outcome considering that Equitana was held in Sydney two weeks after the Championships.

A good range ot exhibitors and a few new ones took part with many new ones keen to return. 34 companies exhibited at the event either in the trade area or in the stable area.

Lower spectator numbers obviously had an impact on traffic through the trade area but most Exhibitors seemed satisfied with the end result as the people who did attend were spending money.







Snapshots




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DRESSAGE
NEW SOUTH WALES
HAMILTON ISLA


Saddleworld


Photo: Franz Venhaas 2013




Saddleworld
Photo: Franz Venhaas 2013




Photo: Franz Venhaas 2013





Thank you to all our Sponsors & Supporters.

We hope you enjoyed your association with the event.

We welcome your feedback and look forward to your continued support

The next Saddleworld Australian Championships will be held

23 to 26 October 2014